



SHELBY TAUBER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Alexander Montalvo, right, and others object in January to the Fort Worth City Council's plans to scrap diversity policies.

The price of defiance on DEI

Carlos Flores sat silent as speaker after speaker at the city council meeting told him he had the power to stand up to President Donald Trump.

"Do not comply with a ransom demand," the newly elected chair of the local Democratic Party begged the council.

"Other cities are fighting, and you should too," another woman said. "Don't bend the knee."

Flores and 10 other council mem-

A Texas city's debate over Trump's ultimatum echoes national dilemma

BY HANNAH KNOWLES
IN FORT WORTH

bers were weighing an ultimatum from Trump: End the city's diversity programs or risk losing all federal funding. If Flores and the five other Democrats on the council stuck together, they could defy Trump and vote to keep "diversity, equity and inclusion" — or DEI — in place.

But Flores, the longest serving among them, didn't like to talk about national politics at all.

SEE DEI ON A8

Fight or Fold: How American institutions are responding to President Trump's demands. A Washington Post series.

Jailed in a state that she said she had never visited

Facial recognition software identified her in Md. bank fraud cases

BY DANIEL WU

HERMITAGE, PA. — To investigators, the case against Kimberlee Williams appeared straightforward.

"It's very obvious it's you," an officer in Montgomery County, Maryland, said to Williams, who was handcuffed to a table in the police department.

Williams had several prior convictions for writing bad checks in Oklahoma, and the person who appeared in surveillance photos, accused of making fraudulent withdrawals in Maryland, looked like a match in surveillance photos — the same build, the same age, the same shape face.

But Williams was adamant. That wasn't her. She lived in Oklahoma and had never been to Maryland, she said, until police arrested her and flew her in to be questioned.

Williams, now 57, offered to take a polygraph test and said she had family members who could provide an alibi for her, according to video of the interview from July 2021 reviewed by The Washington Post. She acknowledged that she had a history of writing

SEE ARREST ON A6

Woman accuses Eric Swalwell of rape

BY LIZ GOODWIN

A woman accused former congressman Eric Swalwell (D-California) of raping her in a West Hollywood hotel in 2018, and said she will make a formal report to the Los Angeles County Sheriff's Office.

Lonna Drewes said at a news conference on Tuesday that she met Swalwell socially in 2018 when she was working as a model

Former congressman denies allegations against him, his attorney says

in Beverly Hills, running a fashion software company and considering a run for city council.

Drewes's attorney, Lisa Bloom, said her client will present evi-

dence to the authorities but not the news media. Bloom provided one photo that shows Drewes and Swalwell at an opening of a restaurant called Avra in 2018. The Washington Post was not able to confirm her account.

An attorney for Swalwell, Sara Azari, said in a statement that Swalwell "categorically and unequivocally denies each and every allegation of sexual misconduct

SEE SWALWELL ON A2



EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/REUTERS

Never forgetting

Phyllis Lowinger holds a photo of victims Tuesday during a recitation of the Jewish prayer for the dead at the Holocaust Memorial Museum's commemoration of the Days of Remembrance.

Trump says talks with Iran may soon restart

BUT HE WON'T BUDGE ON NUCLEAR DEMANDS

Sides far apart on enrichment, the main sticking point

BY KAREN DEYOUNG

President Donald Trump said Tuesday that U.S.-Iran peace talks may resume "over the next two days" in Pakistan, but that he was not pleased with the offer of a 20-year suspension of Tehran's nuclear enrichment program made last weekend by his chief negotiator, Vice President JD Vance.

In an interview with the New York Post, Trump advised reporters who covered unsuccessful negotiations that ended Sunday to stay in Islamabad "because something could be happening over the next two days, and we're more inclined to go there" rather than other suggested venues, including Geneva.

He did not say whether Vance would continue to lead the negotiating team, which included White House envoy Steve Witkoff and Trump son-in-law Jared Kushner.

"I've been saying they can't have nuclear weapons," he said of Vance's offer. "So I don't like the 20 years." Asked about suggestions that a moratorium might encourage Iran to make an agreement, Trump said, "I don't want them [Tehran] to feel like they have a win."

Trump, who last week declared a two-week pause in the now six-week war, has maintained that increased U.S. pressure on Iran, including a blockade of its oil exports through the Strait of Hormuz, will eventually force the regime to give in to his demand that it will "never have a nuclear weapon."

Calling Tehran's refusal to make that promise the sticking point that led to failure of the initial Islamabad negotiations, Trump told reporters at the White House on Monday that he was confident he would prevail. "We agreed to a lot of things, but they didn't agree to that," he said of the nuclear pledge. "I think they will agree to it. I'm almost sure of it. In fact, I am sure of it."

Tehran has long said it has no intention of producing a nuclear weapon — Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the supreme leader killed in an Israeli airstrike at the war's outset, long ago issued a fatwa, or ruling, against it — and the country's current leaders appear prepared to repeat the decree as many times as necessary in efforts aimed at ending the conflict.

But what Trump is really talking about is his demand that

SEE IRAN ON A12



U.S. blockade snares 6 ships leaving Hormuz

BY TARA COPP

U.S. warships confronted six merchant vessels seen departing an Iranian port, forcing them all to turn back, in the opening hours of the Trump administration's bid to counter Tehran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz, military officials said Tuesday.

The U.S. blockade, which took effect Monday amid a shaky ceasefire between the United States and Iran, involves 10,000 American troops, more than a dozen Navy ships positioned in the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea, and an array of fighter jets and drones to surveil commercial vessels in the area, U.S. Central Command said in a post on social media.

Before the U.S. and Israel began the war against Iran, and Tehran closed the Strait of Hormuz in retaliation, about 20 percent of global oil supply — roughly 20 million barrels of oil — and 20 percent of the world's liquefied natural gas trade passed through the strait daily. A global spike in gas prices has increased pressure on the Trump administration to find a resolution to the

SEE BLOCKADE ON A12

Geography powers Iran's grip on strait

BY JÚLIA LEDUR
AND DYLAN MORIARTY

Shipping traffic through the Strait of Hormuz remains constrained a week after the United States and Iran said they would facilitate vessel passage under a two-week ceasefire agreement. Instead, tensions have escalated. After Iran said ships must coordinate with its forces — and, in some cases, pay a toll — President Donald Trump called the demands "extortion" and announced Sunday that the United States would block ships entering or exiting Iranian ports, adding pressure to an already fragile truce.

But even as Washington seeks to squeeze Iran economically, Tehran retains a powerful advantage: geography. Over six weeks of conflict, Iran has halted virtually all traffic in the strait by laying mines, according to its military forces, and exploiting the vulnerability created by its terrain. Even under a U.S. blockade, these factors allow Iran to continue exerting influence over who crosses — and at what risk.

That risk, more than any formal

SEE STRAIT ON A11

IN THE NEWS

Weaponization charge A DOJ report says the Biden administration used overly aggressive tactics to prosecute people who block women from entering abortion clinics. A4

Extreme weather Super Typhoon Sinlaku arrived unusually early in the North Pacific and could be a sign of what's to come. A4

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